

THIRD EYE | SHANKAR AIYAR

Chinese Concerto

It's mystifying how attention is often mistaken for achievement. Last weekend, as Indians applauded the limelight on Prime Minister Manmohan Singh at the G20 meet, Chinese President Hu Jintao went home with real conquests. Symbolic of the ruthless efficiency with which the dragon breathes fire, Hu used the line-up of four major summits to propel China into a higher orbit.

Sure, global leaders sought out the doctor of dismal science for his prognosis, which was not surprising given his erudition and India's emerging status. By some accounts Singh was King at Pittsburgh. But beyond the glitz, the picture is not very rosy. At least the optics suggest we are swaying to a very American tune on the critical issues of climate change, proliferation and agri subsidies at the World Trade Organisation. We are also hemmed in between our traditional position and new ones dictated by our commitment to the Indo-US nuclear deal. This is not to argue that suzerainty has been surrendered but to say that India is not seen to be standing up to its stature of a trillion-dollar economy.

Having a prognosis is good but the best way to predict the future is to simply invent it. To appreciate how China insures its future, consider how Hu engineered economics to achieve geopolitical ends. Before he reached Pittsburgh, he had met the Turkmen president to discuss a gas pipeline project, prospected mining interests with the President of Bolivia, met Nicholas Sarkozy to clinch French participation at the 2010 Shanghai Expo, discussed trade and North Korea with South Korea, got the commitment of newly elected Japanese Prime Minister Yukio Hatoyama to abide by the Japan-China joint declaration on the Taiwan issue and signed an MOU for natural gas with Russia. By the time he met US President Barack Obama on Wednesday, Hu had already punctured all hopes of any pressure tactics on the Chinese currency with a crisp advice that "major reserve currency issuing countries should take into account and balance the implications of their monetary policies for both their own economies and the world". There wasn't much left to be said once he had put the US on the backfoot over its borrow-and-spend economics. But there was more. To counter fears of action on Chinese exports, the Chinese President managed a joint appeal to "fight against protectionism".

It is no secret that growth and scale are key to attaining a place on the high table. The journey to superpower status is fuelled by timing and planning. China saw an opportunity in the September of summits and had clearly planned for it. India did not. China reached the

US armed with arguments, ideas and deals and went home with a bag of goodies for the 60th anniversary of the revolution. Now that's an achievement. Small wonder then that Hu Jintao afforded himself a rare smile as he stood in the first row next to Obama at the photo-op in Pittsburgh.



SAURABH SINGH / www.indiatodayimages.com



RANKED: Olympic and World Championship bronze medallist **Vijender Singh** as the World's No. 1 pugilist in the middle-weight (75kg) category. He is



also the recipient of the Rajiv Gandhi Khel Ratna Award.

NOMINATED: Singer Manna Dey for the Dada Saheb Phalke Award for 2007 by the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting.

AWARDED: Mohamed ElBaradei, director-general of the International Atomic Energy Agency, the Indira Gandhi Prize for Peace, Disarmament and Development by President Pratibha Patil.

APPOINTED: Nalin Surie, as the new high commissioner to the UK. Prior to his appointment, he was serving as secretary (west) in the Ministry of External Affairs.

APPOINTED: Vijai Lakshmi Sharma as director-general of the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence. A 1975-batch officer of Indian Customs and Central Excise Service, she is the first woman to head this department.

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